

Sleep Guide

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Sleep Guide

Getting Started

TL;DR: Go to bed and wake up at the same time every day (even weekends), get sunlight in your eyes within 30 minutes of waking, and keep your bedroom cool (18°C/65°F) and pitch black.

Quick Start

1. Regularity (Consistency)

The body loves rhythm. Waking up at the same time every day anchors your circadian clock. Sleeping in on weekends creates “social jet lag,” which is why Monday mornings hurt.

2. Light Viewing

Light is the primary zeitgeber (time-giver) for your brain.

- *Morning:* View bright sunlight (outdoor light) for 10-30 minutes immediately after waking. This triggers cortisol (good for alertness) and sets a timer for melatonin release ~16 hours later.
- *Evening:* Avoid bright/blue lights 2 hours before bed.

3. Temperature

Your core body temperature must drop by about 1-2°C to initiate and maintain sleep.

- Keep your room cool (~18.3°C / 65°F).
- A warm shower before bed actually helps *cool* you down (with vasodilation - by dilating blood vessels on the skin).

The “Perfect Day” Cheat Sheet

Want to see how this looks in practice? Here is an ideal timeline:

- **07:00 AM:** Wake up, get sunlight in your eyes immediately.
- **08:30 AM:** First coffee (Delaying by 90 mins prevents the afternoon crash).
- **02:00 PM:** Absolute caffeine cut-off.
- **06:00 PM:** Last heavy meal / vigorous exercise.
- **09:00 PM:** Dim the lights, put on blue-light blockers.
- **10:00 PM:** Read fiction, take Magnesium.
- **11:00 PM:** Sleep.

Introduction

“Sleep is the foundation on which the pillars of nutrition and exercise stand.”

For a long time, “I’ll sleep when I’m dead” was the hustle culture motto but we now know that sleep deprivation is directly linked to all-cause mortality, Alzheimer’s, cancer, and obesity. If you are sleeping 5-6 hours a night, you are not “toughing it out”. You are clinically sleep-deprived.

Much like making a great cup of coffee, great sleep is about variables. You cannot force yourself to sleep, you can only create the perfect conditions for sleep to

happen. This guide is about dialing in those variables - Light, heat, chemistry, and psychology to produce high quality rest periods.

You need to take sleep seriously, and do anything to make it happen. Sleep is more powerful than any supplement, and it's free but many of us don't get enough of it, or the highest quality that we deserve.

I have worked the night shift for almost 5 years, and I have watched countless videos on sleep, read books on it, and tried to understand the science of it.

Sleep Architecture

TL;DR: You need both Deep Sleep, for body repair and REM, or Rapid Eye Movement, for brain repair. They happen in 90-minute cycles. Alcohol and THC destroy REM.

The Two-Process Model

Your sleep is governed by two opposing forces:

1. **Process C (Circadian Rhythm):** Your internal 24-hour clock. It makes you alert during the day and sleepy at night, driven largely by light and temperature.
2. **Process S (Sleep Pressure/Adenosine):** From the moment you wake up, a chemical called **Adenosine** builds up in your brain. The more it builds, the sleepier you get. Sleep clears this adenosine.
 - *Note:* Caffeine works by blocking Adenosine receptors, temporarily hiding the fatigue.

Sleep Stages

Sleep is not a monolith. It happens in cycles of roughly 90 minutes.

Stage	Name	Function	Feeling if Woken
NREM 1	Light Sleep	The transition. Twitching (hypnic jerks) happens here.	"I wasn't asleep."

Stage	Name	Function	Feeling if Woken
NREM 2	Light/Core	Memory consolidation. Heart rate slows. 50% of the night.	Groggy.
NREM 3	Deep / SWS	Physical Repair happens. HGH release, immune system cleaning. Occurs mostly in first half of night.	Very disoriented, heavy grogginess.
REM	Rapid Eye Movement	Emotional/ Mental Repair happens. Dreaming. Memory integration. Occurs mostly in second half of night.	Alert, but maybe confused by a dream.

Chronotypes (Owls vs. Larks)

A Chronotype is an inherited pattern that sets your internal timing for sleep, alertness, and peak cognitive output. This is mainly from genetics.

- **Larks:** Natural wake time 5-7 AM. Peak cognition before noon.
- **Owls:** Natural wake time 9-11 AM. Peak cognition in evening.
- **Third Birds:** Somewhere in the middle (most people).

Tip: You can shift your chronotype slightly using light exposure and meal timing, but fighting your genetics too hard usually results in poor sleep.

The Environment (Your Setup)

TL;DR: Treat your bedroom like a cave. Cool, dark, quiet, and optimized for whoever is in it.

Light Control

Melatonin is the “vampire hormone” - it only comes out in the dark.

- **Blackout Curtains:** An important investment. If you can see your hand in front of your face, it's too bright.
- **Eye Masks:** The budget alternative. (See [Tools](#)).
- **Red Light:** If you need a nightlight, use a dim red bulb. Red light has the least impact on melatonin.

Temperature Regulation

Ideal Range: 15.6°C - 19.4°C (60°F - 67°F).

- **Why to sleep:** Your body needs to dump heat to sleep. A hot room prevents this thermoregulation. Warm socks cause vasodilation, helping the rest of the body dump heat faster.
- **Why we wake up:** Conversely, your core body temperature *rises* in the early morning to wake you up. Using a programmable thermostat to warm your room at 6:00 AM, or a smart mattress cover (like *Eight Sleep*), acts as a highly effective, natural alarm clock.

Noise Management

Sudden noises spike cortisol, even if they don't fully wake you up.

- **White/Pink/Brown Noise:** Use a fan or a dedicated machine. “Coloured” noise masks sudden sounds (like a car door slamming) by creating a constant audio floor.
 - *Pink Noise:* Sounds like heavy rain/leaves. Often preferred over the harsh static of White Noise.
- **Earplugs:** Wax or silicone are best for side sleepers. Look for a rating of SNR 35. Loop Quiet 2 are recommended.
- **Earphones:** Bose SleepBuds or Ozlo SleepBuds are well reviewed, but they are very expensive.

Air Quality

CO2 buildup in a small, closed bedroom can ruin sleep quality.

- **Ventilation:** Crack a window or leave the door open if possible.
- **Filtration:** A HEPA filter helps with allergies (stuffy nose = mouth breathing = bad sleep).

Bed Partners & Pets

Sharing a bed introduces motion, heat, and noise that can cause “micro-awakenings.”

- **The Scandinavian Sleep Method:** If your partner steals the blankets or runs hot, use two separate twin-sized duvets on the same mattress. This drastically reduces temperature and movement disruptions.
- **Pets:** While sleeping with a pet can promote psychological relaxation (oxytocin), they often move and disrupt your sleep cycles. If you track your sleep and notice poor scores, try moving the pet to a dedicated bed on the floor.

Sleep Hygiene

The Caffeine Cut-off

Caffeine has a **half-life of ~5-7 hours**. If you drink a double espresso (150mg) at 4:00 PM, you still have ~75mg (roughly a cup of tea) in your system at 10:00 PM.

- **Rule:** No caffeine 8-10 hours before bed.
- **Rule:** Delay morning caffeine by 90 minutes to allow natural cortisol to clear residual adenosine (prevents the afternoon crash).

Alcohol, THC & Sex

- **Alcohol:** It is a sedative, not a sleep aid. It helps you lose consciousness but **blocks REM sleep** and spikes heart rate. You will wake up unrefreshed.
- **THC (Cannabis):** Like alcohol, weed is often used as a crutch to fall asleep faster. However, THC severely blunts REM sleep. This is why heavy users stop dreaming, and why quitting leads to intense “REM rebound” nightmares.

- **Sex:** Mixed data. For some, the post-orgasm release of prolactin and oxytocin aids sleep. For others, the increased heart rate and arousal delays sleep onset. Test what works for you.

Napping

Naps can clear adenosine, which is great for midday fatigue, but terrible if done wrong.

- **The Rule of Thumb:** Keep naps to either **20-30 minutes** (to wake up before entering deep sleep, avoiding sleep inertia) OR a full **90 minutes** (to complete one full sleep cycle).
- **The Curfew:** Never nap after 3:00 PM, or you will lack the necessary “sleep pressure” (Process S) to fall asleep at your normal bedtime.

Exercise

Exercise is a powerful signal for the body clock, but timing matters.

- **Morning/Afternoon:** Cardio and resistance training promote deep sleep (adenosine buildup).
- **Late Evening:** Avoid HIIT or heavy cardio within 3 hours of bed. It raises cortisol and core body temperature, which delays sleep onset.
- **Wind-Down:** Yoga or light stretching is excellent before bed.

Meal Timing & RHR

The single biggest lever you can pull for Deep Sleep is meal timing.

- **The Concept:** Digestion is metabolically expensive and raises your heart rate and body temperature. If you eat right before bed, your body is working, not resting.
- **The Protocol:** Stop eating **at least 3-4 hours** before bed.
- **The Metric:** You want your Resting Heart Rate (RHR) to drop to its lowest point *early* in the night. If you eat late, RHR stays elevated all night, destroying sleep quality.

Screen Time & Blue Light

Screens emit blue light, which mimics the sun and suppresses melatonin.

- **Hard Stop:** No screens 60 mins before bed.
- **Mitigation:** If you *must* use screens, use “Night Shift” mode (iOS/Android) or [Flux \(PC\)](#), and turn brightness to the minimum.

The Wind-Down Routine

You cannot go from 100mph to 0mph instantly. You need a buffer zone.

1. **Warm Shower/Bath:** 60-90 mins before bed.
2. **Brain Dump:** Write down tomorrow’s to-do list. This offloads the anxiety of “forgetting something” from your working memory.
3. **Fiction Reading:** Non-fiction activates the problem-solving brain; fiction engages the imagination (dream-like state).

Supplements

Disclaimer: Supplements are tools, not crutches. Fix your light and schedule first. Consult a doctor before adding supplements, especially if on medication.

Magnesium (Glycinate / Threonate)

Most people are deficient in Magnesium. Take only these. No other Magnesium is effective for sleep.

- **Dose:** 200mg - 400mg taken 30-60 minutes before bed.
- **Glycinate:** High bioavailability, calming effect on muscles. Good for physical relaxation.
- **Threonate:** Only form that crosses the blood-brain barrier effectively. Good for “turning off the brain.”

Melatonin (Use with Caution)

Melatonin is not a sleeping pill. It is a timing signal.

- Most supplements overdose this (3mg to 10mg).

- Use 0.3mg (300mcg) only when changing time zones (jetlag) or resetting a schedule. Daily use can downregulate your own production.

L-Theanine

Found in green tea. Promotes alpha waves (relaxed alertness) and can help calm the “racing mind” before bed.

- *Warning:* For a small percentage of the population, L-Theanine can cause extremely vivid dreams or night terrors. If your dreams become too intense, drop this supplement.

Apigenin

Derived from Chamomile. Acts as a mild sedative to help initiate sleep.

Myo-Inositol

- **Use Case:** Excellent for people who can fall asleep fine, but struggle with waking up in the middle of the night and not being able to get back to sleep.
- **Dose:** Typically 900mg.

Ashwagandha

An adaptogen that lowers cortisol.

- **Use Case:** Highly effective if you suffer from chronic daytime stress that translates into a “wired and tired” feeling at night. Note: It should ideally be cycled (e.g., 2 weeks on, 1 week off) to maintain effectiveness.

Tart Cherry Juice

Contains a natural source of melatonin and procyanidins, which help keep tryptophan (the precursor to melatonin) available to the brain.

- Shown in studies to reduce sleep latency and increase overall sleep duration.
- Look for “Montmorency” concentrate. Be mindful of sugar content; high sugar before bed can spike RHR and disrupt deep sleep.

Tools

TL;DR: Spend money on your mattress, because you spend 1/3 of your life there.

Mattresses & Pillows

- **Subjective:** There is no “best” mattress.
- **Back Sleepers:** Usually need medium-firm and lower pillows.
- **Side Sleepers:** Need softer mattresses (pressure relief for shoulders) and higher loft pillows (to align neck).

Sleep Trackers (Oura / Whoop / Watch)

Trackers are great for trends, but don't obsess over the raw numbers.

- **Oura Ring:** Best form factor, excellent temperature tracking.
- **Whoop:** Best for athletes correlating strain vs. recovery.
- **Apple Watch:** Surprisingly high accuracy for stage tracking compared to EEG.

Sleep Masks

- **Manta Sleep Mask:** Highly recommended. Has “eye cups” so there is no pressure on your eyelids, allowing REM movement. 100% blackout.
- **Silk Masks:** Good for skin, less blackout capability.

Smart Alarms

Apps (like Sleep as Android or Sleep Cycle) or devices that wake you up during **Light Sleep**.

- They use the accelerometer/microphone to sense movement.
- Waking up in Light Sleep avoids **Sleep Inertia** (that “hit by a truck” feeling from waking during Deep Sleep).

Mouth Tape

Sounds crazy, works wonders. Breathing through your nose increases nitric oxide (relaxing your blood vessels) and oxygenation.

- **Micropore Tape:** Put a small piece vertically over your lips.
- **Benefits:** Prevents dry mouth, reduces snoring, improves sleep quality.

Do not tape your mouth if you have consumed alcohol (vomit risk), have a blocked nose/sickness, or untreated sleep apnea.

Nasal Strips

Breathing through your nose increases nitric oxide, reduces snoring, and prevents dry mouth.

- Mechanical strips (like *Breathe Right* or *Intake Breathing*) physically pull the nostrils open.
- Excellent for those with congestion or a deviated septum.

Special Contexts

Shift Work Survival

If you work nights, you are fighting biology.

- **The Commute Home:** Wear **sunglasses** on your drive home. Preventing morning sunlight from hitting your retina is important to keep your body in “night mode.”
- **Anchor Sleep:** If you can’t sleep 8 hours straight, try to keep at least 4 hours occurring at the same time every day.
- **Blackout:** Your bedroom must be pitch black. Foil on windows is ugly but effective.

Women’s Health (The Cycle)

Sleep architecture changes during the menstrual cycle.

- **Luteal Phase (Pre-period):** Body temperature naturally rises, and progesterone spikes. This can cause insomnia or fragmented sleep.
- **Action:** You may need to actively cool your room *more* during this week. Be kind to yourself; sleep efficiency naturally drops here.

Troubleshooting Common Issues

Insomnia (Can’t Fall Asleep)

If you struggle with insomnia, please check out [Clara’s guide](#).

Clara struggles with insomnia and her guide is well detailed and provides citations.

- **The “Gold Standard”: CBT-I:** Cognitive Behavioral Therapy for Insomnia.
- **The 20-Minute Rule:** If you haven’t fallen asleep in 20 minutes, **get out of bed**. Go to another room, keep the lights dim, and read until you are tired. Staying in bed creates a psychological link: Bed = Frustration. **Crucially: Do NOT look at your phone during this time.**

The Racing Mind (Internal Dialogue)

- **Cognitive Shuffling:** Imagine random objects (Cow, Toaster, Planet, Leaf). It disrupts the logical “worry loops” of the brain.
- **Journaling:** “Brain Dump” your to-do list for tomorrow onto paper before bed.

Maintenance Insomnia (Waking Up Early)

Waking up at 3 AM and unable to fall back asleep.

1. **Do NOT Check the Time:** Checking the clock creates “math anxiety” (“If I sleep now, I only get 3 hours...”).
2. **Temperature:** You might have overheated. Throw off a blanket.
3. **Hypoglycemia:** Occasionally caused by a blood sugar drop. A tiny pinch of salt or tsp of honey might help.
4. **Supplement Check:** Consider adding Myo-Inositol to your stack to help bridge sleep cycles.

Nighttime Urination

- **Hydration Front-loading:** Drink most of your water before 6 PM.
- **Electrolytes:** Ensure you are getting enough salt/magnesium; water without electrolytes runs right through you.

Sleep Apnea

If you are consistently sleeping 8+ hours a night but waking up feeling like you didn’t sleep at all, you may have Sleep Apnea (where the airway collapses and you stop breathing momentarily, causing micro-awakenings all night).

- **Action:** Consult a sleep specialist. No amount of magnesium or blackout curtains will fix this; you will likely need a CPAP machine to regain your energy.

The Blueprint Protocol

This protocol is derived from **Bryan Johnson**, who achieved 8 months of perfect sleep scores. It focuses on driving Resting Heart Rate (RHR) as low as possible.

1. Identity: “Professional Sleeper”

- Treat sleep with the same respect as a professional meeting. You don’t show up late to work; don’t show up late to sleep.
- Sleep is not something you “fit in” after your social life; your life fits around sleep.

2. Extreme Fasting

- Johnson eats his final meal at **11:00 AM**.
- **Why?** This gives the body ~9 hours to fully digest before bed.
- **Result:** RHR drops to ~44 bpm immediately upon sleeping, maximizing Deep Sleep time.
- **For Normals:** You don’t need to eat at 11 AM, but move your dinner as early as socially possible.

3. The Power Law of Heartbeats

- Mammals generally get about 1 billion heartbeats per life.
- Keeping your heart rate lower (idling) preserves longevity. High sleep quality = lower average heart rate = slower aging.

NSDR & Yoga Nidra Guide

Non-Sleep Deep Rest (NSDR) or **Yoga Nidra** are tools to manually shift your nervous system from “Fight or Flight” to “Rest and Digest.” Use these if you wake up in the middle of the night or need a nap.

The Huberman NSDR Protocol (Simplified)

- **Position:** Lie on your back, palms up, eyes closed.
- **The Spotlight of Attention:** Imagine a spotlight or flashlight beam.
 - Focus it on your **feet**. Perceive whatever sensations are there (tingling, warmth, contact with the bed).
 - Move the spotlight to your **shins**, then **knees**, then **thighs**.
 - Move it to your **abdomen**. Notice it rising and falling with breath.

- Move it to your **hands, arms, shoulders, neck,** and **face**.
- **Breathing:** Inhale deeply through the nose, and exhale through *thinly pursed lips* (like breathing through a tiny straw). Extend the exhale as long as possible.
- **Visualization:** As you exhale, imagine your body sinking 1 centimeter deeper into the mattress.

The Purpose

By focusing on **sensation** (the feeling of your feet), you shut down the **thinking** (prefrontal cortex) part of your brain. You cannot intensely feel and intensely think at the same time.

Sleep Glossary

Adenosine A chemical that builds up in the brain during waking hours, creating “sleep pressure.” Caffeine blocks adenosine receptors.

Circadian Rhythm Your internal 24-hour biological clock, regulating the sleep-wake cycle, largely influenced by light and temperature.

Cortisol The “stress hormone,” but also the “wake up hormone.” You want a spike of this in the morning, and low levels at night.

Half-Life The time it takes for a substance (like caffeine) to reduce to half its initial amount in the body.

Hypnic Jerk The involuntary muscle twitch sensation of “falling” that occurs during the transition from wakefulness to NREM 1 sleep.

Melatonin A hormone secreted by the pineal gland in response to darkness; signals the body that it is time to sleep.

NSDR (Non-Sleep Deep Rest) Protocols like Yoga Nidra or hypnosis that mimic the brain waves of slow-wave sleep to restore energy without actual sleep.

Sleep Debt The cumulative effect of not getting enough sleep. It can be partially repaid, but chronic debt causes long-term damage.

Zeitgeber An external cue (Light, Temperature, Food, Social Interaction) that entrains your biological clock.

Appendix

NSDR / Yoga Nidra Links

If you are tired but can't sleep, or need a nap but only have 20 mins, use these guided audio tracks.

- [Huberman Lab NSDR \(10 mins\)](#)
- [Ally Boothroyd Yoga Nidra \(20 mins\)](#)

Credits

- **Huberman Lab:** [Sleep Toolkit](#)
- **Matthew Walker:** *Why We Sleep* (Book)
- **Bryan Johnson:** [Sleep Blueprint](#)